Facebook. "This victory is the victory of the masses. It proves TMC occupies the hearts of people of Bengal," she wrote.

However, as the one party with overwhelming clout on the ground, the TMC faces allegations of resorting to desperate acts to decimate the Opposition. For example, CPI(M) candidate Geeta Hansda, who won a GP seat in Kalna in Purba Bardhaman, was allegedly escorted out of the counting booth by TMC workers, who claimed she had switched parties to join them. CPI(M) leader Madhuja Sen Roy alleged that the state police was used to confiscate winning certificates of party candidates. In Bharkunda village in North 24 Parganas, TMC candidate Mahadeb Maati allegedly swallowed ballot papers to deny CPI(M)'s Rabindranath Majumdar a narrow victory.

Admittedly, in 2023, only 9.5 per cent of the total seats were won uncontested—compared with 34 per cent in the 2018 panchayat polls. But it has outstripped 2018 in the sheer scale of violence. The TMC would do well to remember a sobering fact. Less than a year after its win in the 2018 panchayat polls, it got a rude shock in the 2019 general election, winning only 22 out of the state's 42 seats. The BJP came nibbling at its heel with 18 seats. In it, experts saw the vengeance of disenfranchised rural voters. Another wave of anger may singe the TMC in 2024. ■

NORTHEAST

IMPASSE IN MANIPUR

By Kaushik Deka



AP

STILL BURNING
Charred remains of houses after rioting in Sugnu

It has been more than two months since ethnic clashes first erupted in Manipur. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) governments—both at the Centre and in the northeastern state—have drawn flak for the violence that has already claimed nearly 150 lives and shown no immediate signs of abating. The collective failure of the "double engine *sarkar*" to even begin a dialogue between the fighting Meitei and Kuki groups reflects more than just its poor grip over the state's law and order situation—what's gradually being exposed is how the BJP is caught in a bind because of conflicting political interests.

Ever since the violence broke out, there has been a consistent demand—from the Opposition, Kuki groups and even within the BJP—for chief minister N. Biren Singh's removal. He had even typed a resignation letter, dated June 30, but this was torn by a massive crowd that assembled outside his official residence to prevent him from submitting it to the governor. The CM's critics say he staged this "resignation drama" after being asked to quit by the BJP's central leadership. The episode only further exposed the party's dilemma in handling the state's affairs.

CONFLICTING POLITICAL INTERESTS COME INTO PLAY AS PEACE CONTINUES TO ELUDE MANIPUR

The way things have panned out, Biren on the face of it may come across as an inept CM who has failed to control the violence despite the support of the Union government and armed forces. His detractors even allege he has blatantly sided with the Meiteis, his own community. It's on similar lines that Kuki groups claim that Biren's earlier drives against illegal poppy cultivation and encroachment of forest areas were aimed specifically against them, deepening the commu-